



**Carleton
University**

School of Public Policy
and Administration

**PhD in Public Policy
PADM 6011: Theoretical Foundations of Public Policy
Winter 2026**

COURSE INFORMATION

Instructor: Vivian Hoffmann
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Instructor Office hours: by appointment

Classroom: 5208 Richcraft Hall
Link to Brightspace Course Page:
<https://brightspace.carleton.ca/d2l/home/367131>

Time: Mondays 14:25-17:25

LAND ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Carleton University acknowledges the location of its campus on the traditional, unceded territory of the Algonquin Anishinabeg people.

STUDENT RIGHTS AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Carleton University strives to provide a safe environment conducive to personal and intellectual growth, free of injustice and characterized by understanding respect, peace, trust, and fairness. The Student Rights and Responsibilities at Carleton University are available [here](#).

ANTI-RACISM, EQUITY, DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION STATEMENT

An inclusive and transformational university culture requires an environment free from discrimination, harassment and sexual violence where Indigenous ways of knowing and learning inform our systems and practices, and where equitable access to services and opportunities guides all university action. SPPA is committed to ensuring these in our classrooms. For confidential inquiries related to harassment, discrimination and Accommodation response, please contact equity@carleton.ca.

SPPA Statement on Anti-Racism <https://carleton.ca/sppa/sppa-statement-against-racism/>
Carleton University's Equity, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI) Action Plan,
Indigenous Strategy [Kinàmàgawin](#),

Indigenous studies at SPPA: Students who wish to learn more about Indigenous programming in the School and at Carleton are encouraged to contact the Community Coordinator and Administrator, Indigenous Policy and Administration at IPA@carleton.ca. Also, for information about Carleton's Centre for Indigenous Initiatives and the *Ojigkwanong Indigenous Student Centre* (Patterson Hall 228), please visit <https://carleton.ca/indigenous/>.

I. COURSE DESCRIPTION

Calendar description: Addresses the normative and explanatory theories fundamental to public policy. This course introduces theory from ethical, economic, and political/administrative perspectives. Topics may include the influence of ethical considerations from utilitarianism, contractualism, and rights-based traditions; theories of the bureau; market failures and solutions; motivation and agency; rational and public choice; welfare and public goods; incentives; game theory; and political/macro-environmental forces on policy choices.

While a variety of theoretical perspectives are introduced, the course primarily approaches policy from the standpoint of microeconomics and welfare economics. Students are expected to have satisfied the economics requirement for admission to the PhD program prior to taking the course.

We will meet once per week for a 2-hour and 50-minute block, including a 20-minute break. Students are expected to have completed the assigned readings ahead of class. During a typical class, I will give a lecture summarizing and contextualizing the assigned readings. The latter portion of class will be used for in-depth discussion of the material, and/or for presentations of readings by students. Each student will present and lead discussion around one paper during the course of the class. These readings are marked with a ± in the course calendar below.

II. PRECLUSIONS

None

III. LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of the course, students should be able to:

- Describe the nature and implications for normative policy analysis of alternative philosophical perspectives
- Apply micro-economic, game theoretic, and political economic concepts to public policy problems
- Understand and critically assess economic arguments as these relate to public policy

IV. TEXT

- Rosen, H., Tedds, L., Tombe, T., Wen, J.F., and Snoddon, T. 2023. *Public Finance in Canada*, 6th edition. McGraw Hill. (Required) Available on reserve at MacOdrum Library, and for purchase at the at the Campus Store and the [publisher's website](#) (\$129.95).

Other materials listed below are posted in the Course Content section of the course Brightspace page.

V. COURSE CALENDAR

± To be presented by a student

* Optional (all other readings are mandatory include those presented by students)

Course Overview and Introduction to Topic 1 – January 5

Chapter 2, Theoretical Tools of Public Finance, in Gruber, J. *Public Finance and Public Policy*

1. Constrained Utility Maximization, Efficiency, and Other-regarding Preferences – January 12

Bowles, S. “Chapter 3, Preferences and Behavior” in *Microeconomics: Behavior, Institutions, and Evolution*. Pages 93-126.

± Lee, Seung Hyeon and Yoo, Younggeun, “Giving Up”: The Impact of Decreasing Housing Affordability on Consumption, Work Effort, and Investment (November 19, 2025). Working paper.

2. Welfare Economics, Philosophical Roots, and Alternative Perspectives – January 19

Chapter 2, Fundamentals of Welfare Economics, in Rosen et al., *Public Finance in Canada*.

Goodin, R. E. (1995). Chapter 1 of *Utilitarianism as a public philosophy*. Cambridge Press. Pages 3-27

Ashford, E, and Mulgan, T., “Contractualism.” 2018. In Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. Pages 1-11.

± Sen, A., 1984. The living standard. *Oxford Economic Papers*, 36, pp.74-90.

3. Cost-Benefit Analysis – January 26

Chapter 3, Cost-Benefit Analysis, in Rosen et al., *Public Finance in Canada*.

Sen, A., 2000. The discipline of cost-benefit analysis. *The Journal of Legal Studies*, 29(S2), pp.931-952.

± Atkinson, Giles. 2018. “Chapter 14: The social cost of carbon.” in *Cost benefit analysis and the environment: further developments and policy use*. OECD. Pages 335-370.

Assignment 1 due January 28

4. Public Goods, Externalities, and Game Theory – February 2

Chapters 4-5, Public Goods, in Rosen et al.

McCain, R.A., 2010. *Game theory and public policy*. Edward Elgar: Cheltenham, UK, Northampton, MA, USA. Chapter 2 up to and including section 2.4; Chapter 4.

± Fehr, E. and Gächter, S., 2002. Altruistic punishment in humans. *Nature*, 415(6868), pp.137-140.

5. Inequality and Redistribution – February 9

Chapter 6, Income Redistribution, in Rosen et al.

Rawls, J. “A Theory of Justice” (1979) in Shafer-Landau, R. ed., 2013. *Ethical theory: an anthology*. John Wiley & Sons. Pages 582-592.

± Durlauf, S.N., 2011. “Groups, social influences and inequality”, in *Poverty Traps*, Samuel Bowles, Steevn N. Durlauf & Karla Hoff. Princeton University Press, pp.141-175.

Reading Break – No classes

6. Uncertainty, Insurance, and Problems of Asymmetric Information – February 23

Chapter 9, Health Care, in Rosen et al., *Public Finance in Canada*.

Akerlof, G.A., 1970. The market for “lemons”: Quality Uncertainty and the Market Mechanism. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 84(3), 488-500.

Inés Macho-Stadler and David Pérez-Castrillo, 2009. “Principal-Agent Models”. Lecture notes (up to and including Part V.1, Basic Adverse Selection Model)

* Agan, A. and Starr, S., 2018. Ban the box, criminal records, and racial discrimination: A field experiment. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 133(1), pp.191-235.

± Kantarevic, J. and Kralj, B., 2016. Physician payment contracts in the presence of moral hazard and adverse selection: the theory and its application in Ontario. *Health Economics*, 25(10), pp.1326-1340.

Assignment 2 due February 25

7. Taxation– March 2

Chapters 14-16, in Rosen et al.

± Chetty, R., Looney, A. and Kroft, K., 2009. Salience and taxation: Theory and evidence. *American Economic Review*, 99(4), pp.1145-77.

8. Debt Financing, Fiscal Federalism, and Public Choice – March 9

Chapter 7, “Debt Financing and Public Debt” and Chapter 8, “Fiscal Federalism”, in Rosen et al.

Stiglitz and Rosengard, 2015. “Chapter 9 – Public Choice” in *Economics of the Public Sector*, 4th Edition. Norton & Company.

9. Theories of the Public Sector – March 16

Mueller, Dennis. C. 2003. “Chapter 16 - Bureaucracy” in *Public Choice III*. Cambridge University Press. (omit section 16.3)

Stiglitz and Rosengard, 2015. “Chapter 8 – Public Production of Goods and Services” in *Economics of the Public Sector*, 4th Edition. Norton & Company.

*The Ezra Klein Show (podcast): The book I wish every policymaker would read

Ungraded 1-page theoretical model proposal, due March 18

10. Leftovers + One-on-one meetings – March 23

This class will be used to wrap up any remaining content not covered in previous classes. In addition, one-on-one meetings with students will be arranged throughout the week to provide feedback on proposals for the theoretical model assignment.

11. Presentation and discussion of student theoretical models - March 30

Assignment 3 due April 1

12. Presentation and discussion of student theoretical models - April 6

Model write-up due April 8

Final exam, to be scheduled during the formal exam period (April 11 - 23)

VI. EVALUATION

Standing in a course is determined by the course instructor subject to the approval of the Faculty Dean. This

means that grades submitted by the instructor may be subject to revision. No grades are final until they have been approved by the Dean.

Presentation of a paper and facilitation of class discussion	8%
In-class participation	10%
Assignments	12%
Presentation of theoretical model	5%
Write-up of theoretical model	15%
In-person final exam	50%

All written work (assignments, theoretical model) should be submitted via Brightspace by the time class starts on the due date. Assignments due on a date when no class is scheduled are due by midnight. Late assignments will not be accepted and a grade of zero will be entered.

Presentation of a paper and facilitation of associated class discussion (8%)

Each student will choose one of the papers marked with a $\pm$ in Section V to present to the class. Your job is to summarize the main points of the text pose a few discussion questions to stimulate an interesting class discussion. I am available to meet about your understanding of the paper ahead of time, and strongly encourage you to do so. Some of the papers contain technical sections which I can help with the presentation of. A sign-up sheet for these papers will be posted on Brightspace.

Participation (10%)

You are expected to have completed the readings for each class, including those presented by your peers. You will be evaluated on the quantity and quality of your participation in class discussions.

Assignments (12%)

Three short assignments will be given based on the readings and lecture material. These will be posted at least two weeks ahead of the due-date and will include problems that require you to formally work through models described in the readings and lectures, to which there is typically a specific correct numerical or graphical answer, and questions asking you to explain your understanding of the readings. The goal of these assignments is to give you a chance to work through the ideas and models presented to build your understanding of the material.

I encourage students to create study groups to discuss class material, prepare for class discussion, and discuss the assignments. Students should be cautious about working in groups to complete assignments. Assignments submitted to me should be the student's own work. If you are not able to complete the assignments on your own, you will not be able to complete the final exam or comprehensive exam.

Presentation (5%) and write-up (15%) of a theoretical model

Each student will prepare a presentation applying one or more of the theoretical constructs discussed in class to a policy problem related to their research interests. The model should be described using graphical representation, mathematical notation, or both, and be accompanied by a written explanation. The write-up should introduce the policy problem, briefly review previous theoretical treatments, and then describe and justify the student's own theoretical modeling approach (1,500-3,000 words).

Final Exam (50%)

The exam will contain questions similar to those in the assignments. The exam will be held in-person during the final exam period, and will prepare you for the theoretical portion of the comprehensive examination.

Letter grade	CU grade points	Indicates that work is:	% Range	SPPA Explanation
A+	12	Outstanding	90-100	For written work, virtually publishable. Demonstrates exceptional evaluative judgment, outstanding critical thinking, and mastery of technical as well as literary aspects of writing.
A	11	Excellent	85-89	Demonstrates superior grasp of material, very strong critical thinking, and capacity to understand and extend underlying patterns.
A-	10	Very Good	80-84	Demonstrates strong grasp of material, its component parts, and capacity to analyze their relationships to each other.
B+	9	Good	77-79	Demonstrates clear understanding of material and ability to apply concepts. Written work is competent.
B	8	Satisfactory	73-76	Satisfactory, but below average. Demonstrates comprehension of material, reasonable but not strong analytical capacity, with some limitations in the ability to apply concepts.
B-	7	Barely Adequate	70-72	Clearly below average. Demonstrates comprehension and understanding, with limited capacity for application. Communication skills problematic.
C+	6	Less Than Adequate	67-69	Did not demonstrate an adequate understanding of the material or the ability to apply the concepts. Writing and/or presentations show serious problems.
C to D-			50-66	Grades in this range indicate work that is passable in some respects but does not meet the standards of graduate work.
F			Failure	Did not meet minimal requirements.

VII. STATEMENT ON PLAGIARISM

Please be aware that all work submitted as a requirement of PADM 6011 must be both your own work and not consistent to this course. Academic offences are serious infractions and will not be tolerated. Students should consult the University's [Academic Integrity Policy](#) concerning academic integrity and instructional offences.

The University Academic Integrity Policy defines plagiarism as “*presenting, whether intentionally or not, the ideas, expression of ideas or work of others as one’s own.*” This includes reproducing or paraphrasing portions of someone else’s published or unpublished material, regardless of the source, and presenting these as one’s own without proper citation or reference to the original source. Examples of sources from which the ideas, expressions of ideas or works of others may be drawn from include but are not limited to: books, articles, papers, literary compositions and phrases, performance compositions, chemical compounds, artworks, laboratory reports, research results, calculations and the results of calculations, diagrams, constructions, computer reports, computer code/software, material on the internet and/or conversations.

Examples of plagiarism include, but are not limited to:

- any submission prepared in whole or in part, by someone else, including the unauthorized use of generative AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT);

- using ideas or direct, verbatim quotations, paraphrased material, algorithms, formulae, scientific or mathematical concepts, or ideas without appropriate acknowledgment in any academic assignment;
- using another's data or research findings without appropriate acknowledgement;
- submitting a computer program developed in whole or in part by someone else, with or without modifications, as one's own; and
- failing to acknowledge sources through the use of proper citations when using another's work and/or failing to use quotations marks.

Plagiarism is a serious offence that cannot be resolved directly by the course's instructor. The Associate Dean of the Faculty conducts a rigorous investigation, including an interview with the student, when an instructor suspects a piece of work has been plagiarized. Penalties are not trivial. They can include a final grade of "F" for the course.

VIII. INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY

Classroom teaching and learning activities, including lectures, discussions, presentations, etc. – by both instructors and students – are copy protected and remain the intellectual property of their respective author(s). All course materials, including PowerPoint presentations, outlines, and other materials, are also protected by copyright and remain the intellectual property of their respective author(s).

Students registered in the course may take notes and make copies of course materials for their own educational use only. Students are not permitted to reproduce or distribute lecture notes and course materials publicly for commercial or non-commercial purposes without express written consent from the copyright holder(s).

IX. STATEMENT ON STUDENT MENTAL HEALTH

As a university student you may experience a range of mental health challenges that significantly impact your academic success and overall well-being. If you need help, please speak to someone. There are numerous resources available both on- and off-campus to support you. Here is a helpful list of resources:

Emergency Resources (on and off campus): <https://carleton.ca/health/emergencies-and-crisis/emergency-numbers/>

Carleton Resources:

- Mental Health and Wellbeing: <https://carleton.ca/wellness/>
- Health & Counselling Services: <https://carleton.ca/health/>
- Paul Menton Centre: <https://carleton.ca/pmc/>
- Academic Advising Centre (AAC): <https://carleton.ca/academicadvising/>
- Centre for Student Academic Support (CSAS): <https://carleton.ca/csas/>
- Equity & Inclusivity Communities: <https://carleton.ca/equity/>

Off Campus Resources:

- Distress Centre of Ottawa and Region: (613) 238-3311 or TEXT: 343-306-5550, <https://www.dcottawa.on.ca/>
- Mental Health Crisis Service: (613) 722-6914, 1-866-996-0991, <http://www.crisisline.ca/>
- Empower Me: 1-844-741-6389, <https://students.carleton.ca/services/empower-me-counselling-services/>
- Good2Talk: 1-866-925-5454, <https://good2talk.ca/>
- The Walk-In Counselling Clinic: <https://walkincounselling.com>

X. ACADEMIC ACCOMMODATIONS

Carleton is committed to providing academic accessibility for all individuals. Please review the [processes for academic accommodation requests](#) and ensure the link to this information is included in all course outlines/syllabi for courses you are teaching this academic year.

You may need special arrangements to meet your academic obligations during the term. For an accommodation request the processes are as follows:

Pregnancy obligation: Write to me with any requests for academic accommodation during the first two weeks of class, or as soon as possible after the need for accommodation is known to exist. For accommodation details, please see under pregnancy [here](#).

Religious obligation: Write to me with any requests for academic accommodation during the first two weeks of class, or as soon as possible after the need for accommodation is known to exist. For more details see <https://carleton.ca/equity/focus/discrimination-harassment/religious-spiritual-observances/>.

Academic Accommodations for Students with Disabilities: Carleton is committed to providing academic accessibility for all individuals. Please review the [processes for academic accommodation requests](#) and the student guide to academic accommodation [here](#). You may need special arrangements to meet your academic obligations during the term. The Paul Menton Centre for Students with Disabilities (PMC) provides services to students with Learning Disabilities (LD), psychiatric/mental health disabilities, Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), Autism Spectrum Disorders (ASD), chronic medical conditions, and impairments in mobility, hearing, and vision. If you have a disability requiring academic accommodations in this course, please contact PMC at 613-520-6608 or pmc@carleton.ca for a formal evaluation. If you are already registered with the PMC, please request your accommodations for this course through the [Ventus Student Portal](#) at the beginning of the term, and no later than two weeks before the first in-class scheduled test or exam requiring accommodation (if applicable). Requests made within two weeks will be reviewed on a case-by-case basis. For final exams, the deadlines to request accommodations are published in the [University Academic Calendars](#). After requesting accommodation from PMC, meet with me to ensure accommodation arrangements are made. Please consult the PMC website for the deadline to request accommodations for the formally-scheduled exam (if applicable).

Survivors of Sexual Violence: As a community, Carleton University is committed to maintaining a positive learning, working and living environment where sexual violence will not be tolerated, and where survivors are supported through academic accommodations as per Carleton's Sexual Violence Policy. For more information about the services available at the university and to obtain information about sexual violence and/or support, visit: <https://carleton.ca/equity/sexual-assault-support-services>

Accommodation for Student Activities: Carleton University recognizes the substantial benefits, both to the individual student and for the university, that result from a student participating in activities beyond the classroom experience. Reasonable accommodation will be provided to students who compete or perform at the national or international level. Write to me with any requests for academic accommodation during the first two weeks of class, or as soon as possible after the need for accommodation is known to exist. <https://carleton.ca/senate/wp-content/uploads/Accommodation-for-Student-Activities-1.pdf>

X1. POLICY ON CLASSROOM RECORDING (OPTIONAL)

Instructors have the option of including a statement regarding student recording of classroom activities. TLS has [suggested syllabus language](#) that can be used or modified, as needed.